



SUPERPOWERS ON THE SHORE
by Sejal Mehta
PENGUIN VIKING
₹**499; 256** pages



WONDROUS BEINGS
Clockwise from top: an octopus, a luminous jellyfish and a blue button jellyfish

been used to.

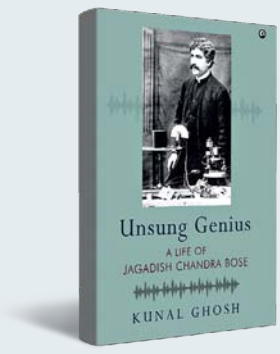
Science abhors emotion, but by dint of objective observation, scientists find out stories about creatures that can titillate the imagination, if told in a lively manner. I appreciated the emotional way in which the observations of scientists, familiar to me as a specialist, are related to an audience of interested onlookers. It's like making bland western food into *chatpata chaat*. The Bollywood song-and-dance interjections are incorporated here as well. For me, the book is very feminine, very Indian, in a very appealing manner. This old fogey enjoyed the experience of reading it and gaining a glimpse of my successors on this planet.

The stories told are more or less accurate even if the facts are dramatised to make them appeal to an audience, already jaded by horror movies of predators lunging out of the dark. By and large, the author has been careful about getting the facts right. However, the bioluminescent organism Noctiluca is portrayed as potentially dangerous, which is inaccurate. The magical phenomenon of bioluminescence that lights up the beaches in a phosphorescent glow on certain nights is well portrayed in the figure. But the dead fish are totally misplaced, Noctiluca is innocuous; portraying it as venomous, "taking life after life" is wrong. Nobody should feel even a semblance of threat casting a shadow on the pleasure of swimming in bioluminescence. I hope this dire warning is corrected in the second edition; and yes, I do hope this book makes a second edition and that Sejal Mehta writes more books appealing to those looking for solace but also excitement and inspiration in the natural world. ■

Though the stories in **SEJAL MEHTA'S** book are mostly accurate, they have been dramatised for wider appeal

–Victor Shahed Smetacek

(*The writer is a retired professor of ocean ecology based at the Alfred Wegener Institute Helmholtz Centre for Polar and Marine Research, Bremerhaven, Germany*)



UNSUNG GENIUS: A Life of Jagadish Chandra Bose
by Kunal Ghosh
ALEPH
₹**999; 496** pages

Though Bose studied in the West, he developed a burning desire to re-establish India as an important centre of learning

Bose was born in 1858 to an affluent family that lived by Brahmo Samaj principles and rejected idol worship. He was passionate about science and nature from a very young age, soon becoming an expert horse rider and a crack shot. His early years as a teacher were difficult, as he battled blatant racism from British colonialists, who constantly put stumbling blocks in his research. But Bose ignored them, even fighting for his rights by refusing to accept a lower salary for years.

As a teacher, Bose showed his students and the public numerous experiments to elucidate the principles of science. His increasing popularity only irritated the British. Throughout his trying times, Bose found numerous sources of unexpected support, guidance and inspiration from such persons as Rabindranath Tagore, Swami Vivekananda and two of the Swami's disciples. That association also instilled in him a deep sense of patriotism and a burning desire to re-establish India as an important centre of learning in the world. Bose did not care about worldly recognition or money. He repeatedly refused to patent his inventions and earn a fortune selling them. That, ultimately, would work against him in the theft of his notebook containing detailed instructions and drawings for inventions that Marconi would use, but claim as a product of his own research.

Just when Bose had made stunning discoveries in physics, he plunged wholeheartedly into applying them to an entirely different field–plant physiology. He invented numerous instruments to monitor electrical activity in plants and their sensitivity to touch, manure, chemicals or drugs. Ghosh plunges into great detail not only about the influence of Vivekananda and Tagore, but also into the mechanics of radio waves and plant physiology.

Skip a chapter or two, if you like–this is still a story worth telling about one of India's most remarkable scientists. ■

– G. Krishnan